

June 2024, adds that women can achieve financial independence by getting the basics of financial literacy in place and working with financial advisors.

"I don't think finance is something learnt in textbooks; it's something learnt by investing and making mistakes," Gupta says.

INVESTING IS NOT LIKE INSTAGRAM LIKES

With her "*Lagey Raho* (keep at it)" mantra, Iyer stresses the importance of patience and the long-term, reminding us that careers aren't like Instagram posts where you seek instant gratification. Whether in investment or one's career, the long game truly matters.

"*Lagey Raho*, and be patient. Career is not like Instagram, where you post a picture and need to see instant likes; longevity is important—be it in the investment journey or your career journey," Iyer says.

Mehra advises women never to forget their dreams and put their aspirations ahead of what people expect.

Vora's mantra is resilience. Never quit, she says, no matter how tough the project or opportunity. She advises young investors to focus on long-term goals instead of being swayed by short-term gains. "Never quit. Whether it's a challenging project or a new business opportunity, perseverance is a key," she says.

Priti Rathi Gupta calls for a dash of financial mindfulness, urging people to invest at least 20% of their income and build a healthy relationship with money. It's essential to balance present enjoyment against future security. She says to follow your passion and work relentlessly but never forget to enjoy life along the way.

"Identify what excites you and have a burning desire to suc-



"Though I was in the minority... I constantly reminded myself that I am here because of my passion"

LAKSHMI IYER

CEO, Investment & Strategy, Kotak Alternate Asset Managers

ceed with tonnes of hard work. Work hard, play harder and enjoy," she adds.

Gupta of Edelweiss Mutual Fund says young people must grab the opportunities before them.

"You are growing up in an India full of incredible possibilities, whether a man or a woman. Previous generations didn't have such opportunities. So, make the most of them," Gupta says.

THE ART OF BALANCING

Mehra says she feels bad whenever women ask her about work-life balance. "No male has ever been asked how they can balance their career with being a husband and a father," Mehra says.

Of course, "change is first required at the family and society level before we talk of any changes at the workplace," Mehra says.

Iyer is more pragmatic. There's no such thing as a perfect work-life balance, she says. What works is effective prioritisation. "It's about managing your time efficiently," she says but admits that external support is crucial. For her, being hands-on at work and home is about choosing the right focus at the right time.

Mehta says women must be present fully in the space they occupy. "The key to balance is being 100% wherever you are," she says. Splitting yourself physically and mentally only leads to imbalance. Choosing your priorities and standing by those decisions is crucial to achieving harmony.

These trailblazers and their stories of resilience, innovation, and leadership encourage women to invest in the markets instead of stashing their wealth as gold jewellery. **BT**

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